AVODAH CONTRACTORS

A GUIDE FOR HORSE OWNERS

BUILDING AN EQUESTRIAN FACILITY

That Works for You and Your Horses

A starting point for the decisions worth considering before and during design.



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INTRODUCTION

FROM EQUINE CARE TO BUILDING PLAN

You already know what works for your horses and how to care for them best. But now, how do you build a stall barn that complements your style and processes, and makes life better for you and your herd? That's where Avodah can help.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01	Before You Break Ground	03
02	Design Around the Operation	05
03	Build Health and Safety Into the Facility	08
04	Choose the Right Structural System	10
05	Plan the Details You'll Live With Every Day	12
→	Start With the Right Build Partner	14

The building process can get complicated quickly. A choice that seems minor on paper can affect the barn for years, and some of the most consequential choices come before their impact is easy to see.

Avodah Contractors helps owners recognize those choices and make them in the right order. Our role is to turn your priorities into a workable building plan.

This guide covers the decisions worth considering before and during design, so you can move into the project with a clear idea of what's right for your needs. From this point forward we will be walking you through the build process, from initial site considerations, to layout and facilities, to finishing details.

> *"Our role is to turn your priorities into a workable building plan."*
>
> AVODAH CONTRACTORS

STEP ONE

01 BEFORE YOU BREAK GROUND

Make sure the site can support the barn you have in mind.



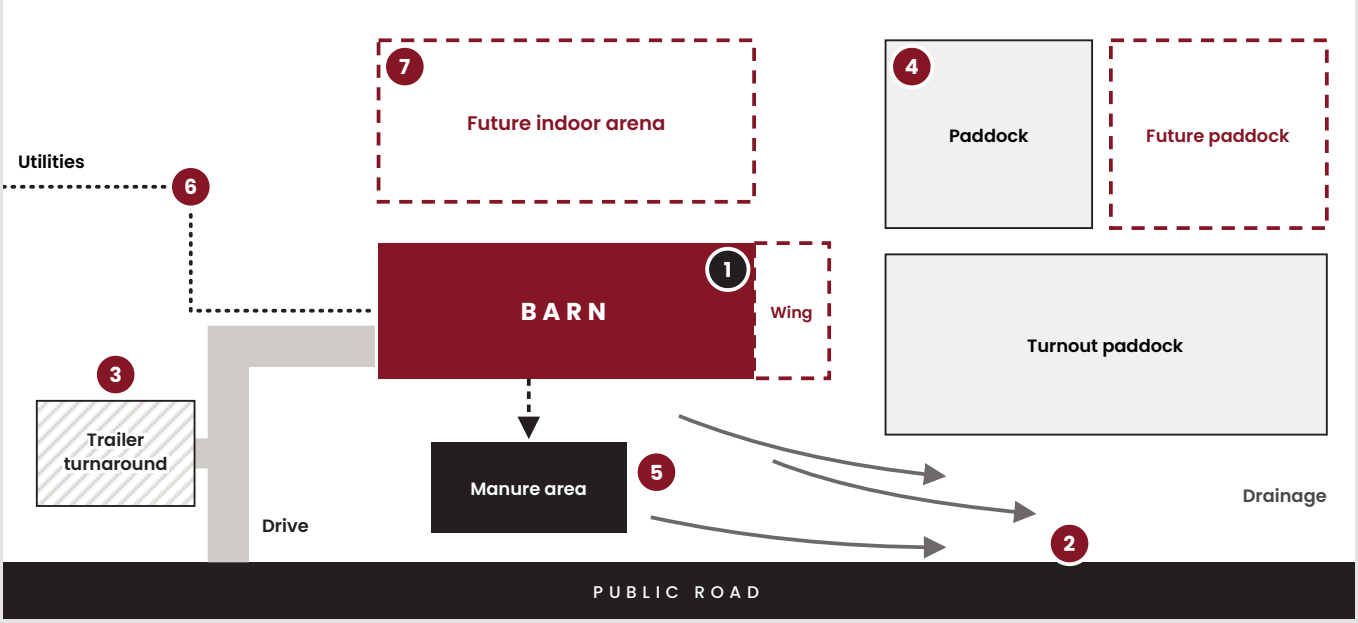
A good site fits into the area around it.

Before design, you must ensure that the plot of land that you are planning to build upon complements the facility you'd like to build. Natural effects of the area can affect convenience and comfort. Spring runoff that leaves the approach muddy, or trailer access that is awkward with winter snow, are a couple examples of potential issues.

As well, the way a barn sits on the property and interacts with nearby buildings or trees can influence natural light and airflow, as well as if future additions still have somewhere to go. You'll want to make sure you've properly inspected the geography of the land to gain a deeper understanding of how your build will sustain over time.

Avodah can help you evaluate a preferred location against the way the whole property needs to function so the design starts with a full-picture of the reality of your space.

FIG. 01 **Site plan: what to place before you build**



1 **Barn placement** Sets drainage, airflow, and options

2 **Drainage** Water moves away from the barn

3 **Trailer access** Room to turn in wet or winter weather

4 **Paddocks** Turnout routes close to the barn

5 **Manure area** Practical access, controlled runoff

6 **Utilities** Planned routes into the barn

7 **Future growth** Arena, wing, more paddocks

Space reserved for later

Check regulations

Once a location is planned geographically, the next step is to make sure the project aligns with regulation.

Zoning and building-code regulation gets confusing fast, and it can vary state to state. There are certain exemptions to regulation in Ohio, but those are not automatic, depending on local requirements.

We'll help you work through the different regulations that are specific for your location and project. Once these details are ironed out, we can get into the fun part: figuring out the design of your stall barn and/or riding facility.

There are certain exemptions to regulation in Ohio, but those are not automatic.

STEP TWO

02 DESIGN AROUND THE OPERATION

Design around the way the barn will be used.



With the property preparation settled, the focus shifts to how the barn layout will work for you and your horses.

Start by thinking through how a normal day unfolds – feeding, turnout, cleaning, grooming, moving horses, etc. Think through your current process and identify moments, even small ones, that might cause backtracking. These problems can usually be fixed with a proper layout. Identifying how the layout can work with your flow will begin to make it feel like it's really yours, rather than a rented space.

Overall, we're after a floor plan that follows the routine rather than works against it. We're after clear movement through the barn with enough separation, so horses, people, and equipment don't constantly compete for the same space.

This becomes even more important in a boarding or lesson facility, where client traffic and staff activity add another layer to the daily flow.

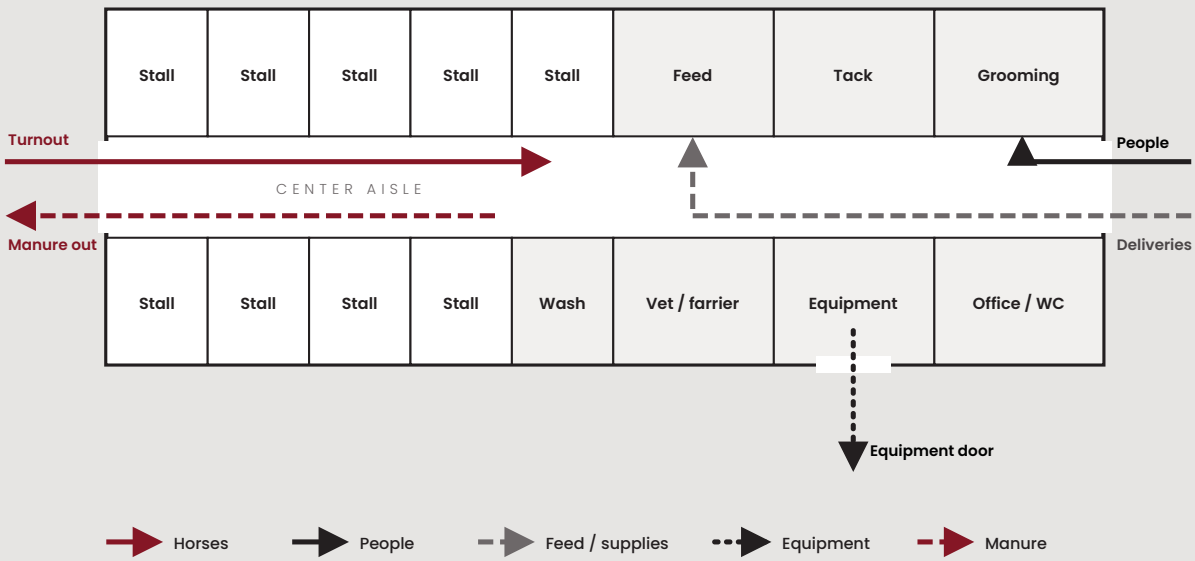
Avodah works with owners through those routines while the floor plan is still taking shape. At the same time, we keep design and budget connected so the money goes toward the parts of the barn that will make the biggest difference in everyday use.

PLAN THESE FIRST

Some decisions shape the rest of the project and become harder to change later.

01 Barn location and orientation
02 Grading and drainage
03 Main utility routes
04 Structural system
05 Major plumbing locations
06 Large doors and openings
07 Primary horse, vehicle, and equipment routes

FIG. 02 Five movements, five separate routes



The floor plan should follow the routine: clear movement through the barn and enough separation so horses, people, and equipment don't constantly compete for the same space.

Build in the flexibility your horses may need

When it comes to your horses' needs, the details matter. The stall plan should reflect how your different horses are actually managed.

A barn where every horse comes in overnight will need something different from one built around more turnout. You may also want some flexibility for a larger horse, temporary medical care, or a change in horse count.

A 12-by-12 stall is a standard recommendation for an average 1,000-pound horse, but size is only part of the decision. How much time a horse spends stalled, and how much separation or visual contact works best for that horse, also affects the design.

12′×12′ A standard recommendation for an average **1,000-pound horse**. Time stalled, separation, and visual contact shape the rest of the decision.

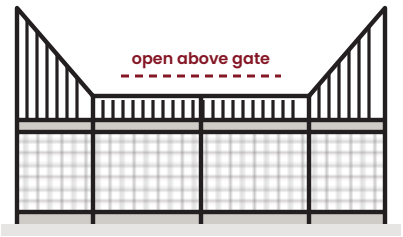
Your horse's needs also factor into the stall fronts and partitions. A more open design can support visibility and airflow, while some horses may need more separation during feeding or recovery.

Whatever style you choose, the details still have to stand up to daily use. Doors, openings, edges, and hardware should all be designed with the way horses actually behave when they are in their stalls.

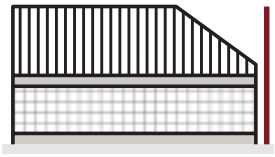
FIG. 03 Three stall-front styles

Red bar marks the see-through height

STALL FRONT



PARTITION BETWEEN STALLS



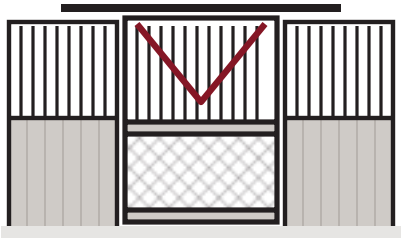
FULL MESH, LOW FRONT

Half-height gates and mesh panels, open above the front.

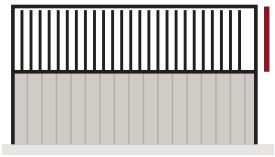
Aisle view	■■■■
Neighbor contact	■■■■
Airflow	■■■■

Side by side: mesh below and bars above, so neighbors see each other along the full wall.

STALL FRONT



PARTITION BETWEEN STALLS



MESH DOOR WITH V-YOKE

Sliding door with a V-yoke for the head and diamond mesh below.

Aisle view	■■■□
Neighbor contact	■■□□
Airflow	■■■□

Side side: solid wood below and bars above, so contact is limited to sight over the lower wall.

STALL FRONT



PARTITION BETWEEN STALLS



OPEN BARS, HEAD-OUT DOOR

Bar grille over a solid lower front, with a door opening for the head.

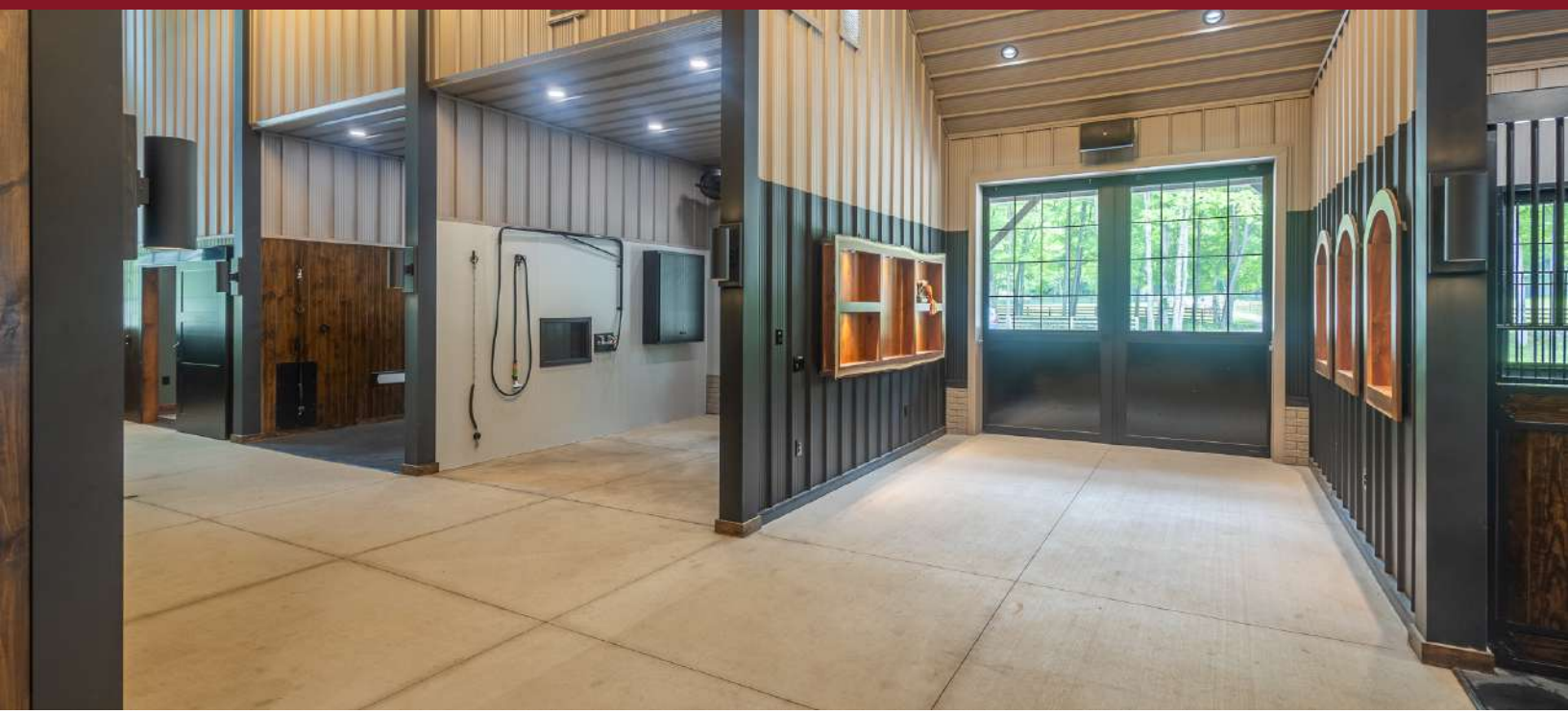
Aisle view	■■■■
Neighbor contact	■□□□
Airflow	■■■□

Side by side: a solid wall between stalls, so neighbors only meet at the front with heads out.

STEP THREE

03 BUILD HEALTH AND SAFETY INTO THE FACILITY

A well-planned barn creates a healthy environment and protects the horses inside it.



Design for fresh-air exchange first

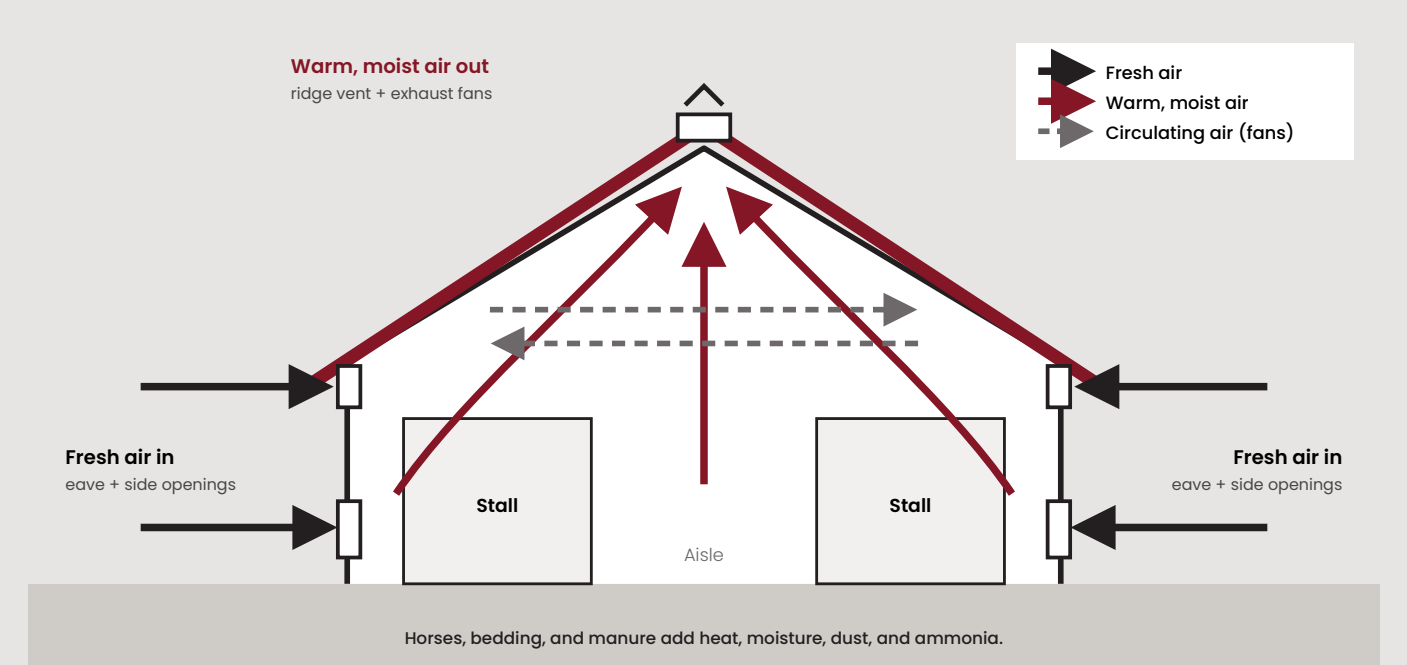
A fan can make a stall feel cooler, but good ventilation depends on replacing stale indoor air with fresh air.

Moisture and airborne irritants build up quickly in a working barn. Natural ventilation uses wind and rising warm air to move fresh air through the building, with lower openings bringing air in and higher outlets allowing warmer air to escape.

Circulation fans can improve comfort in warm weather, but they do not replace fresh-air exchange. Mechanical systems can help control humidity by pulling stale air up and out of rooftop vents.

Because ventilation depends on the building's design, Avodah plans the barn's orientation, openings, and roof for optimal circulation during the design process.

FIG. 04 How natural ventilation exchanges air



Lower openings bring air in; higher outlets allow warmer air to escape. Circulation fans move air around and exhaust fans pull air up and out.

Build fire safety into the design

Fire safety should be prioritized during the design process. The barn's design should reduce the chance that a small problem becomes a fast-moving emergency while preparing a practical way to get horses and people out if one occurs.

These considerations affect everything from where combustible materials are stored to how electrical systems are designed and protected. It also means making sure emergency access and evacuation are considered as part of the building itself.

Avodah considers those risks during design, so fire safety is built into the facility from the start.

FIRE SAFETY, BUILT IN

Storage	Electrical	Access + evacuation
Where combustible materials are stored	How the electrical system is protected	Emergency access and a practical way out for horses and people

STEP FOUR

04 CHOOSE THE RIGHT STRUCTURAL SYSTEM

The structural materials and systems should be determined by the way you'll use the space.



Evaluate the roof as a complete system

It is easy to focus on the roofing material because that is the part you see. Its performance, however, depends on the full assembly beneath it.

Insulation, ventilation, and condensation control all influence how the roof handles changing weather and conditions inside the barn. That is why broad rules such as "metal roofs are too hot" or "this material is quieter" do not tell you much by themselves.

Features such as overhangs become more useful when their placement responds to where shelter from weather will be used most often. Avodah evaluates the complete roof system in relation to the building it has to protect.

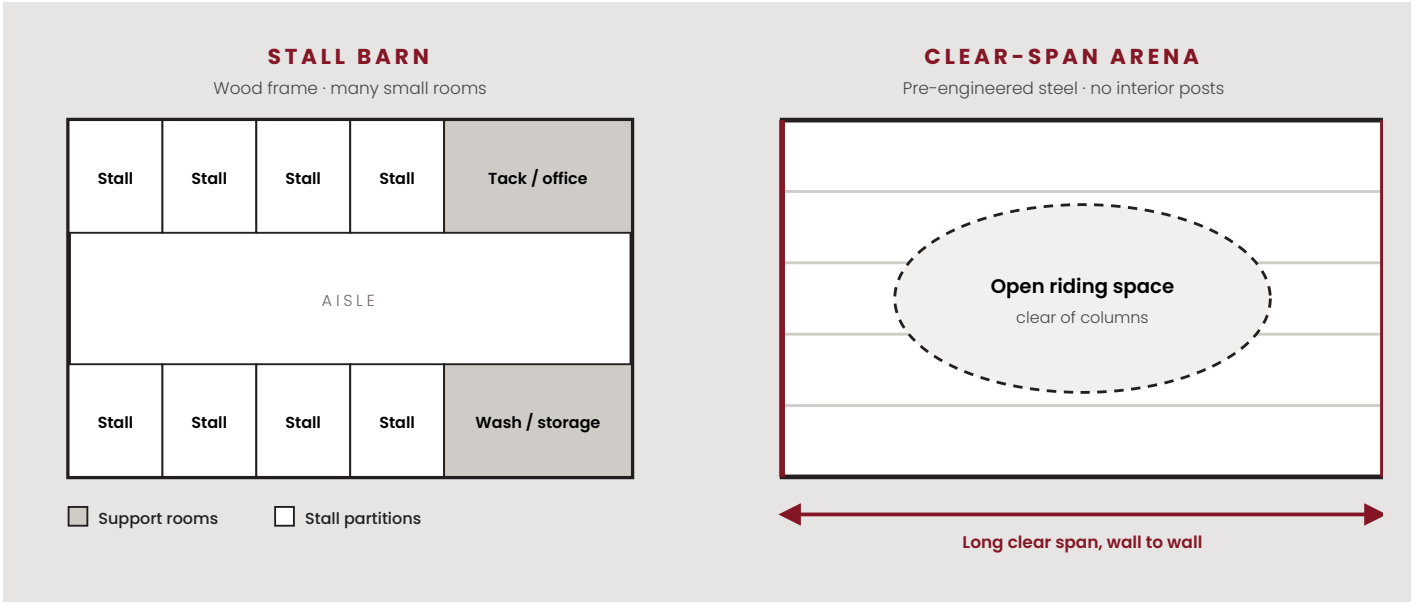
Match the structure to the job

Different parts of an equestrian facility may call for different structural solutions.

Woodland Acres is a good example of how Avodah used wood framing for the 13,020 sq foot stall barn and a pre-engineered clear-span steel system for the 27,560 sq foot arena. The barn needed a structure that accommodated its divided interior spaces, while the arena needed a wide, unobstructed riding area.

Using different systems allowed each building to do its job well. Carry that principle into your own project: choose the structure around what the space needs to accomplish rather than forcing the entire facility into one approach.

FIG. 05 One facility, two structures





AVODAH PROJECT
WOODLAND ACRES

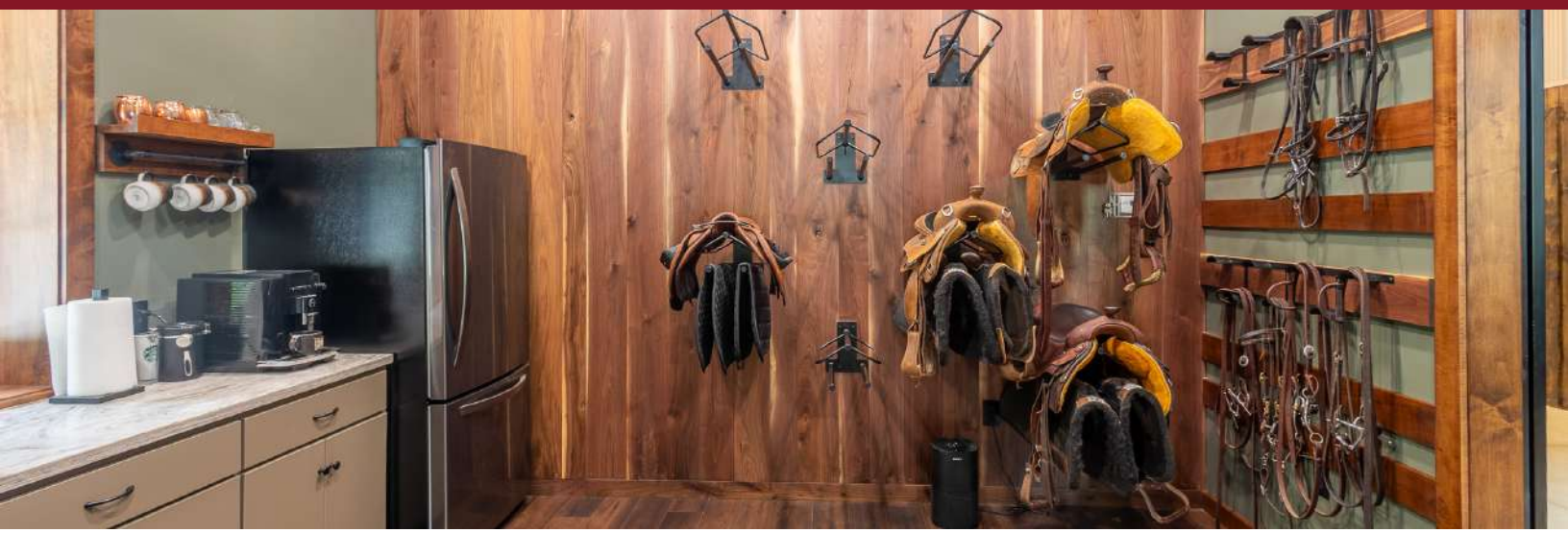
13,020 sq ft
Wood-framed stall barn

27,560 sq ft
Pre-engineered clear-span steel arena

STEP FIVE

05 PLAN THE DETAILS YOU'LL LIVE WITH EVERY DAY

Design utility and support systems to work for you.



Make every day easier

Some of the decisions that look smallest on a drawing become the ones you notice most once the barn is in use. Where you reach for water, how far you carry bedding, or how easily a surface cleans can all affect your daily routine.

Daily efficiency often comes down to distance and interruption. If the hose is far from where you use it or if cleaning stalls sends you through the busiest part of the barn, you will add extra work to completing tasks.

Power works the same way. Outlet locations and electrical capacity should follow where equipment will actually be used, rather than forcing the routine to adapt to the building.

You also want to think about the movement of supplies before you build. The barn should make it easy to bring what you need in and move waste out without sending either through the busiest horse traffic.

Avodah uses your routine to determine where fixed systems and service routes will serve you best. We work out those decisions during design and check them again during construction, while there is still an opportunity to adjust them.

Choose materials for the way the barn will be used

The material conversation changes as you move through the barn. A stall floor must perform under a horse every day, while a tack room may let you prioritize appearance and organization.

The flooring's finish surface matters in each area, but so does the base and drainage beneath it, because they affect how the floor handles moisture, wear, and cleaning over time.

The same principle carries through the rest of the interior. The right finish depends on what that particular space will be exposed to and how much maintenance you want it to require.

Support spaces should be planned just as deliberately. Storage and work areas should reflect what you need close at hand instead of absorbing whatever square footage happens to be left over.

Avodah works through those selections as the design develops, when the purpose of each space is clear enough to make the choice in context.

FIG. 06 **Utility and support spaces**





STALL FLOOR VS. TACK ROOM

One must perform under a horse every day. The other may prioritize appearance and organization.

NEXT STEPS

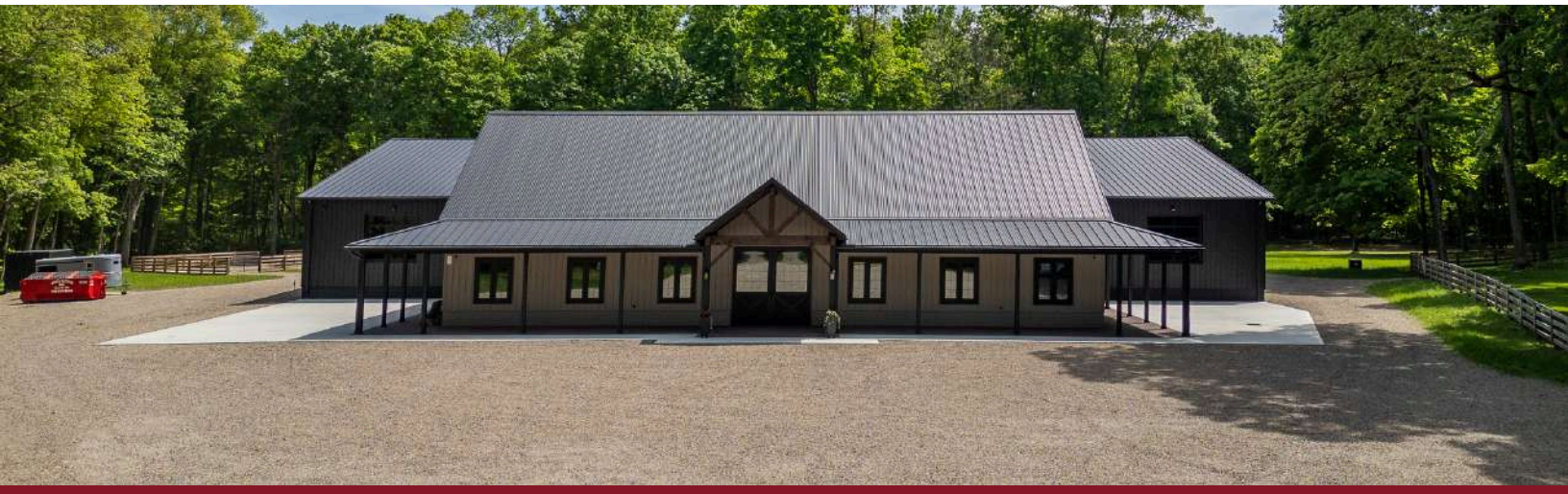
START YOUR EQUESTRIAN BUILD WITH THE RIGHT BUILD PARTNER

You know your horses and the way you want to care for them. Avodah brings construction experience to turn that knowledge into an equestrian facility that works for you day in and day out.

Our role is to help you make the important decisions in the right context, before one choice limits another. We stay involved as the project develops, so someone keeps the building, the budget, and the decisions connected from design through construction.

That approach reflects what the Avodah name means to us: work, worship, and service. For our clients, that means being dependable, communicating clearly, and taking responsibility for the details that can make a barn easier to live with for years to come.

WORK	WORSHIP	SERVICE



READY TO TALK THROUGH YOUR BARN?

If you are planning an equestrian facility within 50 miles of Wooster, Ohio, bring Avodah into the conversation while you still have room to shape the project.

CALL AVODAH CONTRACTORS

330-601-1324

to start the conversation.